Mesa
SCHOOL OF BUSINESS

BYOB CHALLENGE

STUDENT HANDBOOK

Build Your Own Business

Seven weeks. One real business. Everything you need to run it.

7 WEEKS • ₹1L CAPITAL • ₹4L TARGET • 5 MILESTONES • MESA FLEA FINALE

Cohort PGPSLE27 • 2026 • Mesa School of Business

1. The challenge

For the next seven weeks you are not a student on a course — you are a founder with a real business, real money and real customers. You and three co-founders — some you choose, the rest allocated by Mesa — will find a product, source it, brand it, put it online, and sell it across every channel you can reach, finishing with a live sell-off at the Mesa Flea. Mesa lends you up to ₹1,00,000 interest-free. Your job is to turn it into ₹4,00,000 of verified revenue and pay every rupee back.

What	Detail
Duration	7 weeks — 3 online (pre-term) + 4 on campus
Your team	4 co-founders
Capital available	Up to ₹1,00,000 interest-free debt
First tranche	₹30,000 at Milestone 1
Revenue target	₹4,00,000 verified
Mesa Flea stall rental	₹10,000 per team
Repayment	Every rupee back by 30 September 2026
Grand finale	The Mesa Flea — Sunday, 6 September
Academic weight	Up to 20% of your CGPA (10 credits)
Where everything goes	outclass@pg27.mesaschool.co

What you're here to do

GOAL 01 BUILD	GOAL 02 BECOME	GOAL 03 RETURN
Build a real D2C business from nothing and generate ₹4,00,000 of verified revenue in seven weeks.	Become a founder — rapid execution, creative problem-solving, relentless selling, collaborative leadership, and mission first, role second.	Deploy up to ₹1,00,000 of Mesa's money responsibly, turn it into a 4x return, and repay every rupee.

2. Your seven weeks

Wk	Dates	What happens
1	20–26 Jul	Launch; product discovery, supplier selection
2	27 Jul–2 Aug	**M1** — pitch & raise ₹30,000; Website V1
3	3–9 Aug	Order placed; early sales push; B2B lead generation
4	10–16 Aug	Campus begins; **M2** — brand + e-commerce live; Product Showcase;
5	17–23 Aug	**M3** — first performance-marketing campaign; Raise upto ₹20k for perf. marketing
6	24–30 Aug	**M4** — multi-channel report;
7	31 Aug–6 Sep	**M5** — Mesa Flea; capital repayment

3. How you're graded

BYOB carries up to 20% of your CGPA. Half of it is what your team earns; the other half is how you personally show up.

Component	Weight	Score	What it measures
Revenue achievement	50%	5	Verified team revenue, graded in bands
Mentor feedback	30%	3	Your mentor's assessment of you
Team feedback	20%	2	Your co-founders' rating of you

Revenue bands (5): under ₹50,000 = 0.5 • ₹50,000–₹1L = 1 • ₹1L–₹1.75L = 3 • ₹1.75L–₹2.5L = 4 • above ₹2.5L = 5. Only verified revenue counts.

What your mentor scores (3): Mentor scores you on check-in attendance, critical thinking and problem solving and execution rigor.

What your team scores (2): each of your co-founders rates you from 1 to 5 on the five Founder Code dimensions below. Consistently low ratings cost you credits even when the team hits its revenue target.

The Founder Code — what your team rates you on

Dimension	What it looks like in practice
Rapid Execution	You ship today's task today. Speed of decision beats elegance of plan.
Creative Problem-Solving	When you hit a roadblock, you find another way instead of an excuse.
Relentless Selling	You keep asking for the sale after the first no — every day, every channel.
Collaborative Leadership	You make your teammates better and share what's working.
Mission First, Role Second	You do whatever the business needs, not only the job you picked.

4. The rules, plainly

If this happens	This is what follows
Your product and supplier submission is rejected	Mesa assigns you a product and a supplier, and a **₹2,000 penalty** applies.
You join the programme after Week 1	Mesa assigns you a product and a supplier. **No penalty.**
A member from another team joins your team mid-challenge	A **₹500 per day** charge applies, and profit sharing among the founders is revised to include them.
You miss a milestone deadline	The possible loss of your next tranche, and escalation to your mentor and Mesa.
You log revenue without proof	It does not count — not towards revenue, not towards your grade.
You don't repay by 30 September 2026	Non-repayment is penalised with credit loss.

Your non-negotiable rhythm

- **Update your team tracker every day.** Every sale, every cost, the same day — with proof attached.
- **Share sales updates in mentor groups every day.** You report the day's numbers, not your intentions.
- **Milestone reviews with your mentor** at each of the five gates.
- **Bottom-performer reviews.** If your team is called into one, come with a plan, not an explanation.
- **Your team is fixed once formed.**

5. The seven-week playbook

Revenue builds by phase. Every week below tells you what Mesa runs, what you must do, and what has to be true by Sunday night.

PHASE 1 · Weeks 1-3	PHASE 2 · Weeks 4-5	PHASE 3 · Weeks 6-7
₹25,000	₹1,50,000	₹2.50,000 → ₹4,00,000

Phase	Week & milestone	Workshops	What you must do	Deliverables
PHASE 1 Discover & Finalise Weeks 1–3 **~₹25k**	**Week 1** 20–26 Jul *Discover product & supplier*	• **WS0 — Launch** • **WS1 — Picking Profitable Products** • **WS2 — Supplier Selection**	• Shortlist two or three product ideas and check for real demand. • Get written quotes from your primary supplier and a **backup supplier based in Bangalore**: price, MOQ, lead time. • Take all two or three ideas to your mentor for a **pre-pitch review** before you submit.	☐ 2–3 ideas pre-reviewed with mentor ☐ Product and supplier chosen ☐ Backup Bangalore supplier quoted
	Week 2 27 Jul–2 Aug **◆ M1 — Pitch, raise ₹30k, store live**	• **WS3 — How to Pitch + Razorpay setup** • **WS4 — Website V1** Idea submission deadline Pitch & raise ₹30k	• Submit your shortlisted product and supplier by the deadline. • Pitch to your mentor: demand evidence, unit economics, channel plan, first-order size. • **Get your store live with working payments** — Website V1 and Razorpay - This is crucial for early revenue • Size your first order to what you can sell in ten days, and name your first ten customers.	☐ Idea submitted on time ☐ ₹30,000 raised ☐ Live store + payments working ☐ First order sized and costed
	Week 3 3–9 Aug *Order, sell, B2B leads*	• **WS5 — First 10 Customers + B2B Sales**	• Place your order and confirm the delivery date in writing. • Start selling now — do not wait for campus. • Build and work a named B2B prospect list. • Log every sale and expense the same day, with proof attached.	☐ Order placed and confirmed ☐ First sales logged ☐ B2B prospect list ☐ Early revenue building

Phase	Week & milestone	Workshops	What you must do	Deliverables
PHASE 2 Build the Sales Engine Weeks 4–5 **₹1.5L**	**Week 4** 10–16 Aug **◆ M2 — Brand + store live (Wk 3-4)**	• **WS6 — Setting up E-commerce** • **WS7 — Brand & Packaging** Product Showcase @ Mesa (Fri)	• Build your brand: name, logo and packaging. • Upgrade the store you launched — better photos, copy and checkout. • Present at the Product Showcase. • Use the Independence Day weekend to sell; don't treat it as a pause.	☐ Brand and packaging ready ☐ Enhanced store live ☐ Showcase presented
	Week 5 17–23 Aug **◆ M3 — First PM campaign**	• **WS8 — Performance Marketing (Meta & Google)**	• Get Meta Ads tracking and Google Analytics firing before you spend a rupee. • Define one audience, one offer, one creative, pointing at a page that converts. • Get your mentor's approval to unlock the ₹5,000 marketing tranche. • Know your **expected ROAS** before you launch, then read the data daily and decide.	☐ Tracking live and tested ☐ Campaign running ☐ Upto ₹20,000 tranche unlocked
PHASE 3 Optimise & Scale Weeks 6–7 **₹2.5L → ₹4L**	**Week 6** 24–30 Aug **◆ M4 — Multi-channel report**	• **WS9 — Social Media Marketing**	• Post on social every day and keep the content calendar running. • Produce your multi-channel report: what each channel earns and costs, plus the action plan. • Prove your marketing spend paid back • Put money only into the channel that is already profitable.	☐ Daily social posts running ☐ Report + action plan submitted ☐ Order for flea is placed
	Week 7 31 Aug–6 Sep **◆ M5 — Mesa Flea & repay**	• **WS10 — Success at the Flea** Mesa Flea — grand finale (Sun)	• Pay your ₹10,000 stall rental, then budget separately for inventory, display, signage and a cash float. • Test your UPI/QR payments before the doors open — queues kill sales. • Keep the daily social posts running through the final week. • Sell hard at the Flea, make the final push to ₹4,00,000, then reconcile and return the capital.	☐ Stall set up and staffed ☐ Payments tested ☐ Final revenue logged ☐ Capital returned

6. The money

Mesa's capital is debt, not a prize. It arrives in stages, each unlocked by proving something. Nothing is released because you asked nicely, and nothing is released twice.

Tranche	Amount	What unlocks it	When
Tranche 1	₹30,000	M1 — product and supplier locked, demand validated, pitch passed	Week 2
Marketing A	₹5,000	A campaign plan with tracking already live	Week 5
Marketing B	₹15,000	Proof that the ₹5,000 paid back before you scale	Week 6
Further	up to ₹1L total	Milestone performance plus a strong, logical sales plan — at mentor and Mesa discretion	Ongoing

Your ₹10,000 Flea stall rental

Every team pays **₹10,000 to rent its stall** at the Mesa Flea — exactly as you would pay for a pitch at any real flea market. **This is the rental only.** Inventory, display, signage, packaging and your cash float are all extra and come out of your own working capital.

Budget for the rental *and* everything on top of it from Week 5. Teams that leave it to the final week arrive under-stocked at the single biggest sales day of the challenge.

Know your unit economics before you spend a rupee

If you cannot fill in this table for your own product, you are not ready to order stock. The example is illustrative — your numbers will differ, but the shape should not.

Line	Example	What to aim for
Selling price	₹499	What customers actually pay, not your wish
Landed cost (product + packaging + delivery)	₹230	Under half your selling price
Contribution margin	₹269 (54%)	50% or better — this is what funds everything
Cost to acquire the order (ads)	₹120	Comfortably below your margin
Profit per order	₹149	Positive from the very first order
Orders needed for ₹4,00,000	~800	Know this number by heart

The five numbers you should know at any moment

- **Verified revenue** — sales you can prove, which is the only kind that counts.
- **Contribution margin** — what's left from each sale after the landed cost.
- **Cash on hand** — what you can actually spend today, which is not the same as revenue.
- **Your ROAS on paid ads** — revenue from the online channel against what you spent to get it.
- **Capital outstanding** — what you still owe Mesa, due 30 September 2026.

7. Choosing your product and supplier

This is the most important decision of the whole challenge, and you make it in Week 1 with the least information you will ever have. Get it right and you spend seven weeks selling; get it wrong and you spend them firefighting. Your mentor applies exactly the criteria below — so apply them to yourself first.

Start with a pre-pitch review — don't submit cold

Before the Week 2 submission deadline, take **two or three shortlisted ideas** to your mentor for an informal pre-pitch review. Bringing a choice rather than a single idea is what makes the conversation useful — your mentor can compare them, point out the sourcing or margin problem you haven't spotted, and tell you which one is worth committing to.

Teams that do this clear the idea submission far more often than teams that submit cold. It costs you one conversation and can save you a ₹2,000 penalty and an assigned product.

Your product must

- Have evidence someone will pay before you spend anything.
- Carry a margin that supports a 4x return.
- Sell online, offline, to businesses, and at the Flea.
- Arrive fast — no long lead times, no customs risk.
- Have repeat purchase or volume potential to reach ₹4,00,000.
- Be free of licences you cannot obtain in seven weeks.

Your supplier must

- Be confirmed in writing — price, MOQ and lead time.
- Have a named **backup supplier in Bangalore**, with a second quote already in hand.
- Solve packaging and delivery, not just the product.
- Accept a first order (~₹20k) small enough to protect your cash.
- Not be a single point of failure for your whole business.

Tends to work

- **Consumables and repeat buys** — snacks, drinks, coffee, edibles.
- **Personalised and gifting** — custom mugs, hampers, photo gifts.
- **Print-on-demand merch** — tees, totes, stickers, low inventory risk.
- **Festive and seasonal** — Independence Day and early-festive lines.
- **Everyday accessories** — phone, desk and bottle items that demo well.

Steer well clear of

- **High-ticket considered buys** — too few sales to reach ₹4,00,000.
- **Imports and long lead times** — delays cost you selling weeks.
- **Perishables** with spoilage or cold-chain risk.
- **Regulated goods** — ingestibles, skincare claims, anything needing a licence.
- **Thin-margin resale or dropship** — no pricing power, no return.
- **Anything needing R&D** or a certification you don't already have.

⚠ THE MISTAKE THAT COSTS TEAMS THE CHALLENGE

Committing to one supplier with no backup, or to imported goods with a long lead time. When that supplier slips — and one usually does — you lose the weeks you needed for selling, and you cannot get them back. Your backup must be **in Bangalore**, so you can reach them in person and restock in days rather than weeks. Have that second quote in hand before you place your first order.

8. Selling — the only thing that counts

Revenue is half your grade, and it is the half nobody can do for you. Assume nothing sells itself: every rupee comes from someone deciding to buy because you asked them to.

Your first ten customers

Start with people you can reach today — your cohort, your family, your neighbourhood, your WhatsApp groups. These sales are entirely valid and they count. Their real value is the feedback: the objection you hear three times is the one to fix in your pitch and your pricing.

Channel	How to win it	Watch out for
Online store	A fast mobile page, clear photos, obvious price, one-tap payment. Drive traffic from social and WhatsApp before you pay for ads.	A store that is 'almost ready' for a week
Offline & pop-ups	Campus stalls, hostel floors, local events. Highest conversion you will get — you can answer objections face to face.	Going without stock or a payment QR
B2B & bulk	Corporate gifting, cafes, salons, societies, college clubs. One order can beat a week of retail.	Long payment terms — get paid, or it isn't revenue
WhatsApp & direct	Broadcast lists, status, personal follow-up. Cheapest channel you have and the fastest to test an offer.	Spraying the same message with no follow-up
Mesa Flea	The single biggest sales day. Sharp pricing, bundles, a stall that stops people walking past.	Under-stocking, or a payment queue

> **What actually counts as revenue**
>
> A sale counts only when the money has been received and you can prove it — a bank or UPI record, an online store order. **Paid pre-orders count. Promised orders, unpaid invoices and 'they said yes' do not.** Log it the same day with the proof reference; Mesa spot-checks and unproven entries are removed.

The five objections you will hear most

They say	You do
“It's too expensive.”	Don't discount first — that teaches people to wait for a sale. Restate what they get for the money, then offer a smaller pack or a two-for bundle.
“I'll buy later.”	Later rarely comes. Ask for a paid pre-order now with a firm delivery date — a paid pre-order counts as revenue today.
“Send me the details.”	Send them while you are still standing there, then ask for the order before you walk away.
“I don't need it.”	Either you're talking to the wrong person or leading with the wrong benefit. Ask what they would use it for, then re-pitch once.
“Let me check with someone.”	Find out who actually decides and get in front of them. In B2B that is whoever holds the budget.

9. When things go wrong

Something will break — that is normal and it is not the end of your challenge. What separates teams is how fast they act. Here is the first move in the five situations that catch teams out.

Situation	Your first move
Your supplier slips or the order is late	Call your **backup Bangalore supplier** the same day — this is exactly why you have one, and why it has to be local. Tell your mentor before the deadline, not after it.
The product isn't selling	Change the offer before you change the product: price, bundle, photos, audience. A full pivot costs weeks you cannot get back.
Your ads are burning cash	Stop spending. Fix the tracking, the offer or the landing page first. Never scale a campaign that hasn't paid back.
A co-founder has checked out	Raise it inside the team first, then with your mentor. Peer and mentor feedback are individual — staying silent protects nobody, including you.
Your team is called into a bottom-performer review	Turn up with numbers and a plan, not an explanation. Ask which team is doing it better and copy what works.

10. Questions you're probably about to ask

#	Question	Answer
1	Why are we doing BYOB?	It teaches startup fundamentals by making you run a real business, and it leaves you with proof of work rather than a certificate.
2	Does BYOB affect my CGPA?	Yes — up to 20%, from revenue plus mentor and peer feedback.
3	How is my team formed? Can I change it?	Each team of four is part self-selected and part Mesa-allocated. Once formed it is fixed for the challenge.
4	What can I sell? Can I change later?	Anything with a clear path to ₹4,00,000. You may pivot, but every pivot costs you selling time you cannot recover.
5	Can I put in my own money? Do I keep the profit?	Yes to both — you keep everything you earn once Mesa's capital is repaid.
6	How does the capital reach us?	In three to four milestone-linked tranches. Mesa has discretion and withholds funds if milestones are missed.
7	Do we really have to repay it?	Yes — it is interest-free debt, repaid in full by 30 September 2026. Non-repayment is penalised with credit loss.
8	Can we skip a milestone?	No. All five are mandatory and dated. Hitting them early is fine; skipping is not.
9	What if we miss a deadline?	The possible loss of your next tranche, and escalation to your mentor and Mesa.
10	What support do we actually get?	Curated resources, expert workshops, and weekly mentor check-ins. The selling is yours.
11	Why is selling weighted so heavily?	Because it is the one skill every founder needs and the only proof that someone wants what you built.
12	What works online versus offline?	Online: social, SEO, influencers, ads and WhatsApp. Offline: pop-ups, campus events, local markets and B2B tie-ups.
13	Can we sell to classmates and family?	Yes — those sales are valid and count. Just don't let them be your only channel.
14	How much time will this take?	Around 15–20 hours weekly of timetabled building and selling.
15	What do the top teams get?	Features on Mesa's channels, lunch with a founder, and leaderboard recognition.
16	Can I reuse my MSL product?	No. BYOB needs a new idea; it is a separate track with different teams.
17	What is the Mesa Flea?	The grand finale on Sunday 6 September — a public event where you sell live to customers, families and alumni. Each team pays ₹10,000 to rent its stall.
18	How is revenue verified?	Through your daily tracker plus receipts, screenshots and UPI records, with BYOB team spot checks. Only paid sales count — paid pre-orders included.
19	What if our team isn't performing?	Tell your mentor immediately — Mesa may trigger a pivot, restructure the capital, or step in directly.
20	Where does everything get submitted?	outclass@pg27.mesaschool.co, which is also your first point of contact for anything unclear.

Mesa School of Business — BYOB Student Handbook — Cohort PGPSLE27, 2026